

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
Servants of Peace ~ How to...be calm
August 3rd, 2025



"Boating at Vinalhaven", Frank W. Benson, 1920

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Abraham Ross, *Guest Organist*

Fantasie in E-flat op. 18: *Larghetto e cantabile* (1808) – Johann Nepomunk Hummel

Fantasy and Fugue in C minor / major (~1840s) – Charles Zeuner

Organ Sonata, Op. 65: I. *Allegro Moderato* (1908) – Horatio Parker

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Rev. Fregin & Lauren Seely

God speaks!
with excitement!
with enthusiasm!
with new life!

God is present!
God is with us!
nothing can separate us!

Even when we feel unsure,
unclear,
confused,
even when we feel broken to the core of our being –
we hold fast to God's love,
and God's acceptance,
because we are always welcome in God's home.
Together we will each, once again,
feel like a well-watered garden.
Full of life!
Radiant in the sun!

There will be goodness, there will be love,
there will be a garden of delights,
in a place where we all know,
we are home.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

To You, O God, All Creatures Sing

LASST UNS ERFREUEN

To You, O God, all creatures sing, and all creation, everything
Sings Your praises, alleluia! Your burning sun with golden beam,
Your silver moon with softer gleam.
Sing Your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your wind that blows the tempest by, your clouds that sail across the sky
Sing Your praises, alleluia! Your morning rises with a song,
And lights of evening sing along.
Sing Your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your flowing waters, crystal clear, make melodies for you to hear,
Sing Your praises, alleluia! Your fire bountiful and bright,
Remembering your warmth and light,
Sings your praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

To You, O God, day after day, Your planet earth in every way,
Sings Your praises, alleluia! As savory fruit and fragrant flower
show forth Your glory and Your power,
Singing praises, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Once again, Holy One,
we step aside from the busy-ness of our lives
to encounter within ourselves and each other
that which we call sacred –
to open ourselves to the healing, hope-filled words,
found in the rich and welcoming presence of
community, and to sing their power
into songs of promise and hope.

*Once again, Holy One,
for we have been here before,
sought a holiness in our hearts
yet failed to notice that what we really lacked
was meaning – a gift much deeper,
yet as present as our need.*

Once again, Holy One,
we come to learn.
May we learn to understand the difference
between success and meaning.
And may we be open to all the ways your dreams
for us, are beginning to arise.

*On this day may we know,
the goodness we dream of,
is here and now.*

*We pray all of this as those who hear
and speak words of hope,
and seek to live them.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen.

***Introit**

"My Peace"
Cathedral

WOODY & ARLO GUTHRIE, arr. DAVID HARRIS

***The Lord's Prayer**

Lauren Seely

We are invited to pray in our own tradition and language.

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

We have gathered in this sacred place,
knowing every place is sacred
where we find peace and energy,
where beauty flourishes,
where we share our minds and our hearts.

On this day, let us celebrate
the richness and diversity of life
in the presentness of God.

This morning may the Peace and Presence of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Lauren Seely

For these words of the ancients whose wisdom we welcome in our present,
Thanks be to God!

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

*Dear One,
closer to us than our own hearts,
farther from us than the most distant star,
you are beyond naming.*

*May your powerful presence become obvious
not only in the undeniable glory of the sky,
but also in the seemingly base
and common processes of the earth.*

*Give us what we need, day by day,
to keep body and soul together, because
clever as you have made us,
we still owe our existence to you.*

*We recognize that to be reconciled with you,
we must live peaceably and justly with others,
putting hate and bitterness behind us.
We are torn between our faith in your goodness
and our awareness of the evil that can form in your creation,
so deliver us from the temptation to despair.*

*Yours alone is the universe and all its majesty and beauty.
So it is.* [jburklo, 2010]
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"Ombra mai fu" from *Serse*
Anna Caplan, Soloist

G.F. HANDEL

"Never was a shade of any plant dearer and more lovely, or more sweet."

Message

How to...be calm

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Fregin

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Amen"
Cathedral Choir

KELLY MCCANDLESS

*Doxology

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

*Prayer of Offering

Lauren Seely

Gracious God, Source of all Blessings,
You have been extravagant in your generosity.
You have planted within us the seeds of Hope.
You have nurtured within us the saplings of Faith.
You have harvested the fruits of your Creation and
spread before us the feast of all possibility.

Words cannot express the gratitude with which
we come before you.

May we embody our thanks with extravagant generosity.
May we offer our lives to you in acts of compassion for one another.
May we walk gently upon the earth, ever mindful of your gifts
of Breath, of Love, of Life itself. [Anne G. Cohen]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

The world we now return to, is a world filled with
challenges, with crises, with pain, with disappointment.
We go as people who know these things intimately
because we have felt them, experienced them,
and railed against them.

*Yet, we also go now as those
who would see not only what the world is,
but what we can make it be.*

In these days – and in all the days to come –
may our hands, our hearts, and our voices
be turned toward making it so!

Go in peace
In peace!
Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

“Creation”
Laude

WILLIAM BILLINGS

*Hymn for the Journey

In the Midst of All Our Living

NETTLETON

In the midst of every blessing may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May our words be filled with gratitude; may our glad heart humble be.
As a holder of a blessing may we share it gratefully.

In the midst of every trial may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of comfort, ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we find the strength within us; may we sense it everywhere.
As we face what must be handled may we find truth we can share.

In the midst of all our living may our hearts be filled with grace.
Streams of goodness ever flowing call for songs of highest praise.
May we seek and find encouragement; may our choices worthy be.
As we journey on together, may we know integrity.

-Words @ Scott Kearns 2008, inspired by Robert Robinson, 1758

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Abraham Ross, Guest Organist

Organ Sonata: IV. Fugue - Parker

Inside The Music

“Handel’s “Ombra mai fu” opens his opera *Serse*, and remains one of his most beloved pieces. For me, it is concentrated peacefulness. The music seems to hang in the air, completely undisturbed as it stirs us to calm. In the opera, the main character, *Serse*, sings lovingly to a plane tree whose presence brings him into a deep calm connectedness with life. Handel has an enduring reputation as a composer with a seemingly endless gift for infectious melodies. Many of his hooks, like “Hallelujah!,” are still with us today. My 3-year-old daughter was just singing it today, for example. “Ombra mai fu” stands out in the arias of his day, in that it is written in only one part. His typical aria is three parts (ABA). Within this one part, however, he weaves hook after hook. Each new melodic moment settles even as it excites. We are brought into the magic of connection to self and the divine. And then it happens again, and again, and again. I have found that the hardest part about calm is remaining there. I can feel calm and connected for a moment, and quickly get distracted. Handel solves this for us, at least for the length of this aria, with novelty that flows from similarity. We have sung Kelly McCandless’ “Amen” many times here, and had the pleasure of performing it with them the same week it premiered. It reminds us that we all flow from and are connected to the divine. It is a song of promise, woven together from faith and cosmic perspectives to insist that we all matter, and then punctuated with a resounding “Amen!” The broadness of the divine has space for everyone. We can all rest in the calm of this definitive knowledge.

We begin the service with one of America's strongest voices for compassion in Woody Guthrie, and end with America's first composer in William Billings. Billings' exciting melodic thrust made him a megastar during the American Revolution and thereafter. He was known alongside other Boston names like Paul Revere and John Adams. His "Creation," like McCandless' "Amen," reminds us that we are part of a much greater, divine whole. As he considers this life in context, he finds calm in the great cosmic churning. His response is a musical romp that lights up with joy." – Dr. David Harris

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